A Hitchhiker's Guide to Flourishing

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[1]With the Flourishing Team

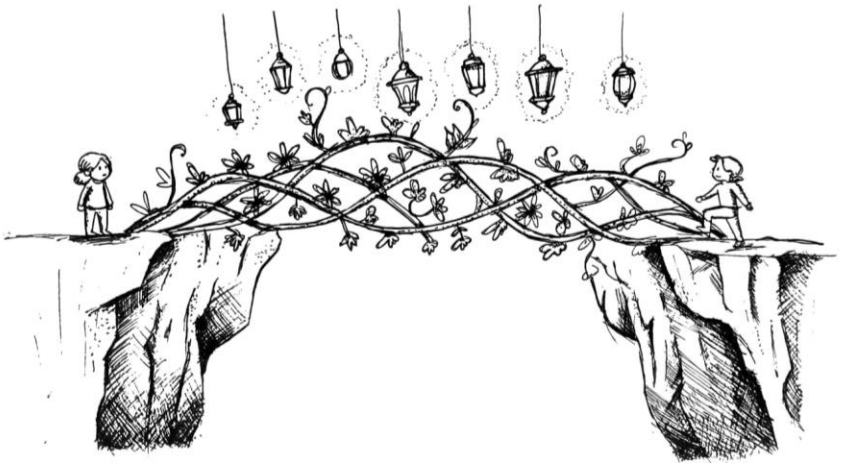
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Foreword

Lying awake at night, you probably ponder how to go from plus two to plus seven in your life, not just how to go from minus five to minus three.

-Martin Seligman, *Authentic Happiness* (2002)



People have been focusing on how to move from suffering to stability, but often without planning for the future. That plus two to plus seven is the space between surviving and thriving, which is what researchers call flourishing.

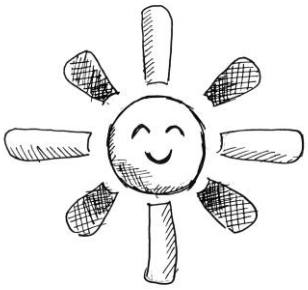
Flourishing is an extensive word, and everything we encountered came with its own perspective for where flourishing begins, and…if it really ends! Drawing inspiration from others, notably: Aristotle, Seligman, VanderWeele, Corey Keyes, Carol Ryff, Barbara Fredrickson, and so many more.[2] The challenge was deciding what was worth saying and delivering that information into something meaningful to deliver to you, the reader.

[2]This paper is formatted in the Edward Tufte style. Side notes and annotations are places along the text for parallel reading, rather than footnotes.

Disclaimer: Your mind will probably wander a few times as you read this. That's not a flaw! We are naturally wired to be shortcut creatures, taking the path with the least amount of time. The problem is that flourishing doesn't have a shortcut. Every researcher came to the same conclusion from a different direction: the easy route and the meaningful route are rarely the same road.

What you are reading is our very best attempt to hold all of that at once, elegantly.

Happiness and Life Satisfaction



> *Flourishing goes beyond happiness, or satisfaction with life. True, people who flourish are happy. But that's not the half of it. Beyond feeling good, they're also doing good-adding value to the world.*
>
> -Barbara Fredrickson, *Positivity* (2009)

Happiness is a strange thing to chase. It rarely appears when you are looking directly at it, nobody wakes up and schedules genuine joy for 4:30 in the afternoon. Instead, it arrives unexpectedly, finally understanding something that frustrated you for weeks, or hearing someone say, "I'm proud of you," when you weren't expecting it.

Barbara Fredrickson, a researcher in positive psychology, argues that these emotions are not simply pleasant experiences; they broaden our awareness, strengthen relationships, and help us build resources for the future. Though, happiness alone is an unreliable measure of a life. Happiness tells us how a moment feels, but not always what that moment means.[3] At the scientific level, happiness is just a chemical release. Dopamine, serotonin, a neutral signal your brain sends when something registers as a reward. But it doesn't know the difference between laughing with a friend and something far darker. This emotion doesn't tell anything about whether the trigger was morally good, and if it was really worth it. Which is why researchers stopped using happiness as the only marker.

[3]For example, serial killers report feeling satisfied and the addiction makes them feel relief.

In fact, happiness is borrowed, traded, shared, deeply instinctual and animal. It comes from the people who believed in us, encouraged us, and showed up for us. Tyler VanderWeele's research on flourishing similarly emphasizes close relationships as one of the central domains of a thriving life. Their happiness becomes part of ours, not because our achievements belong to them, but because no meaningful achievement happens in complete isolation.[4] Here's something to chew on: if you accomplished something really special and had no one to tell, would you feel the same? Most people would instinctively say no. We don't create in a vacuum, but usually towards people even if it's not direct. Life cannot be measured only by how many pleasant moments with others it contains, because some of the things we value most are difficult while we are experiencing them. It's kind of like staying up all night for that one long term project your teacher

[4]Even achievements that we do on our own are almost always dedicated to someone or include something.

assigned you. But you still kept going because…well, you needed that grade. Even though you probably wouldn't feel happy in that moment, it's still the stuff people reminisce about the most later. It's simply one part of life, which psychologist Martin Seligman argues through the PERMA model. Positive emotion is just 1/5 of the framework. The other four are engagement, relationships, meaning, and accomplishment.

Flourishing asks not only, "Was I happy?" but also, "Was this a life I was truly present for?", and most importantly "Did my presence here matter to anyone else?"

Mental and physical health



> *Feelings of worth can flourish only in an atmosphere where individual differences are appreciated, mistakes are tolerated, communication is open, and rules are flexible.*
>
> -Virginia Satir, *The New Peoplemaking* (1988)

Here's some food for thought: What is the difference between not being sick, and being well? Aren't they the same thing? You wake up, nothing seems wrong, nothing hurts, and you get through the whole day. It's all fine, right…right?? However, most people think mental health works like a light switch. You're either struggling or you're completely alright. But Corey Keyes figured out its more than that.[5] It's actually a spectrum, and most of us are actually living in the middle of that spectrum.

He called that area languishing, not depression[6]. It's the distinct feeling when something is missing and you just can't quite put your finger on it. You're getting through your days, showing up to school. Nothing is technically wrong, but nothing feels particularly right either. It's not that you're sick, you just aren't well.

Think of your mental health like a plant. You can have the highest quality seed in the world, but if you put it in the wrong soil, in a room without sun and forget to water it, it's not going to thrive. It might even look fine from a distance, but the plant is just barely alive. That's the point Satir is making. The soil is the environment you live in. You need to have healthy conditions surrounding you: open communication, appreciating differences, and giving you the room to make mistakes and be human![7] Without conditions such as these, it's going to be difficult to grow when you are surrounded by negative energy.

In 2024, only 25% of people across 16 countries were considered to be flourishing. That means 3 out of 4 people are either getting by, languishing, or struggling. This could be the person next to you in class, or the person whose Instagram posts make their life look effortless.

So the question worth asking isn't "are you okay?" Pay attention to the environments you put yourself in! Is the environment surrounding you giving you your best potential to grow? As you can see, the first priority isn't the 4 am morning wake up or

[5]Keyes's model proves that health and illness aren't opposite ends of the spectrum, they are separate, independent axes.

[6]Languishing is defined as the absence of mental health, rather than the presence of mental illness.

[7]Self-determination theory notes that individual dysfunction is rarely internal, but a logical outcome of the environment.

journaling every night. It'll be difficult to create systems like these when your mental health is crushed by the environment you put yourself in. So, take a look at where you're spending most of your time and who you're spending it with! Trust us, it will make the biggest difference.

The second thing is to move your body. There is so much research connecting physical and mental health. So, you should involve physical health throughout your daily routine instead of just a weekly plan.

The UVA flourishing course says that you should stop waiting for life to be "good" before you decide to show up fully. Don't wait for that moment, just show up anyways, especially on the harder days because that shows real personal growth.

Meaning and Purpose



He who has a why to live can bear almost any how.
-Viktor Frankl, *Man's Search for Meaning* (1946)

We often hear that we need to "find our purpose", as if every person has one hidden calling waiting to be uncovered[8]. As if meaning is just one more artifact in a museum waiting for someone to finally walk past the right exhibit! But purpose and meaning are not the same thing.

Purpose asks, "What does this allow me to do?" While meaning asks, "Why does this matter to me?" While Purpose is about function, meaning is about significance. You can choose to work a job with lots of purpose, but it can have almost no meaning and feel completely hollow to you.

Say, a car tire. Its purpose is clear, it keeps a car moving safely. If it breaks, it is replaced. Most would never think about it again. Now, there is a different object, taking the form of an ordinary rock sitting in a drawer. To anyone else, it may be one of the 7.5 quintillion rocks on Earth.[9] They might walk past it without noticing. But to you, it is the rock you picked up on a family vacation before moving away from your old residence. The rock is not rarer, more useful, or more valuable than before. The difference is the relationship between you and the object. It stopped being just a rock and became a piece of memory. The only thing changing is the relationship between you and the rock.

Meaning does not exist entirely inside things;[10] it emerges from the connection between things and the people who experience them. We yearn for meaning even when it isn't visibly there, and sometimes we find it in places we weren't looking. For example, it reminds us of students pulling more meaning from classic literature such as Romeo and Juliet and Moby Dick than the auteur ever intended to put in it. Are we in the age of overanalyzing? Perhaps. But then again, the fact that we can't stop looking for meaning in everything might itself be the most human thing about us.

Flourishing, then, is not necessarily about discovering one grand purpose that explains your entire existence. It is about building a

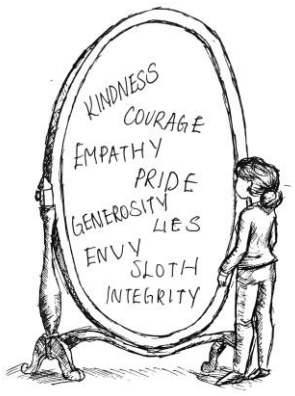
[8]The idea human life has a "calling" stems from teleological philosophy, whereas modern psychology sees purpose as constructed.

[9]Statistically, the rock is likely one of the big 10 mineral groups.

[10]Frankl's logotherapy rests on the idea that meaning derives from cognitive interpretation.

life where your actions connect to something you find meaningful. It's recognizing that meaning can grow in places you don't always expect. A 'failed' attempt, a forgotten afternoon, an ordinary conversation over boba. None of it - is insignificant. It's all part of the larger story.

Character and Virtue



Waste no more time arguing what a good man should be. Be one.
-Marcus Aurelius, *Meditations*, Book 10, §16 (tr. Staniforth)

No one will think of themselves as a bad character, as we try to think the best of ourselves. We think that we're good, even great people in our heads. But Marcus Aurelius was a Roman emperor with practically unlimited amounts of power and money. Someone like him in such a high position wouldn't need to benefit from bettering himself right? Well, he actually wrote notes for himself every day on how to be better, and they were known as the Meditations.[11] It was keeping him accountable from not just preaching virtue but living a life of it. The original Greek title is *Ta eis heauton*, literally translating to "things to one's self".

[11]There isn't any evidence that he intended it for publication, and it actually survived by accident.

So, character isn't something you name for yourself, but what you still choose to do even when no one is watching.

Penn's positive psychology research says everyone has something called signature strengths. You can identify a few of these yourselves. These are virtues that show up naturally for you even when you're on autopilot. So, identify your top strengths, write them down somewhere and deliberately use them in new ways this week.[12]

[12]Seligman's research shows that using these strengths in new ways creates lasting increases in happiness.

Step one: It's knowing who you actually are. Take 10 minutes to take the VIA Character Strengths survey if you haven't already. It's usually more accurate than what you'd guess about yourself.

Step two: is what Haidt's NYU flourishing course calls a self-change experiment. Instead of only reading tens of essays and complete lecture videos (they probably do this anyways), students are prompted to select a specific behavior or daily habit to improve over the duration of the semester. Instead of making end plans, they are building systems for measurable change. Then, students document what they tried to change, what they did to change it, and how it went.[13]

[13]Leverage the if-then planning, which uses specific targets to reduce reliance on willpower.

Most people already probably know what they need to work on, but whether you choose to get up and do something about it.

Close social relationships



> *No society can surely be flourishing and happy, of which the far greater part of the members are poor and miserable.*
>
> -Adam Smith, *The Wealth of Nations*, Book I, Ch. VIII (1776)

Of all six domains, this one might be the easiest to dismiss. Relationships - yeah, we get it. Be kind to people around you, call your mom who keeps checking on you, try not to eat lunch alone. But Adam Smith, the "father of modern economics" looked at society and concluded that none of it mattered if most people were poor and miserable.[14] Though, not poor in the financial manner. Poor social connections. It feels miserable when you are standing in a full room and somehow still feel completely alone.

That's the world a lot of us are already living in. In 2021, more than a third of Americans reported experiencing serious loneliness, and that's not a small number. Think about what it actually feels like to have someone who really knows you. Not someone who follows you on socials[15], or someone you say "hi" to in the hallway to be polite. We're talking about that person who knows the version of you that exists at 1am when you just need to vent, trusting that they got your back. Most of us can count those people on one hand.

The Harvard Study of Adult Development followed people for eighty (yes, eighty) years, and when the researchers looked back at everything collected, the biggest predictor of health and happiness in later life wasn't career success, money, or even intelligence; but it was the quality of their relationships. It was never about how many friends you have but keeping the ones close to you that you can count on.

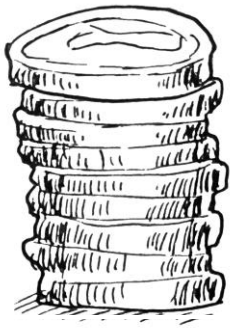
The Stockholm School of Economics discovered something similar from a completely different angle. Their research on what they called the "Fika Factor", the Swedish tradition of shared coffee breaks. It showed that consistent social interaction does more for your personal wellbeing compared to a raise at work, which does sound nice, but it's about the balance. Essentially, talking to someone over a cup of caffeinated drink (or boba) will make a huge difference for your sanity and well-being.

[14]Smith's definition expanded past material poverty, but included dignity required to participate and be accepted into society

[15]Parasocial bonds offer the feeling of closeness, but without it going both ways, they remain a hollow illusion.

So, do one thing. Pick one person you have been meaning to reach out to. Message, or call them. Your relationships are the backbone to a flourishing life. And without them, everything you build on top is less stable than you think.

Financial and material stability



> *To be a virtuous person is to display, by acts of will, all or at least most of the six ubiquitous virtues: wisdom, courage, humanity, justice, temperance, and transcendence.*
>
> -Martin Seligman, *Authentic Happiness* (2002)

At some point in your life, someone has told you that money can't buy happiness, but they weren't telling you the whole story. It's tempting to treat money as either the answer to every problem or something completely unrelated to a meaningful life.

Amartya Sen argued that well-being is not simply about the resources someone owns, but about the capabilities those resources create. Income is part of the environment surrounding flourishing. It can create room to create, care for others, explore, leave situations, and invest in people and ideas past survival.[16] Think of financial stability like a good pair of shoes for a runner. You don't win the marathon because of them, but it's a boost to how far you can get. Aristotle put it plainly in the Nicomachean Ethics that "The life of money-making is in a sense of life of constraint, and it is clear that wealth is not the good of which we are in quest, for it is useful in part as a means to something else." (Aristotle, Nicomachean Ethics, Book 1).

Opportunities alone do not guarantee a flourishing life. Aristotle wrote that the purpose of life was not merely to possess external goods, but to use them toward a life of virtue and fulfillment. A person can have every external sign of success and still feel completely disconnected from what they are doing. Resources can open doors, but they cannot decide which doors are worth walking through.

In *To Have or To Be?*, Erich Fromm questions whether people sometimes confuse owning more with becoming more. It's a trap, because buying so many things feels like progress as it's measurable. A life built entirely around accumulation can become strangely empty, because objects only matter through the meaning and experiences attached to them.[17] A thousand possessions can disappear into the background, while one ordinary object can carry an entire memory.

[16] They create opportunities so a person can choose how to act, and what to become.

[17] When we try to make everything meaningful, we dilute experience until no single object has weight.

Financial stability, then, is a possibility, not a guarantee; which cannot create purpose, character, or relationships, but it can make them more attainable. It's the Wi-Fi password because it doesn't tell you what to do once you're connected, but without it you're not doing much either.

Conclusion



Tell me, what is it you plan to do with your one wild and precious life?
- Mary Oliver, The Summer Day (1990)

Congratulations, you made it to the end! We hope something in here made you stop and make your mind wander.

It really does come down to these six domains, which have to work together. Happiness without meaning is just comfort. Relationships without depth are just company. Success without character is just performance. Think of it like sitting on a bench that has legs missing. You can sit down and do your best to balance, but the moment someone sits next to you, the chair and both of you go down.

The Global Flourishing Study found that the wealthiest, most developed nations were not the ones scoring highest. It was about whether people felt their lives had deeper meaning and whether they felt genuinely connected to others.

So we will leave you with one question to ponder on: which of the 6 domains are you actually tending to, and which ones have you been ghosting? Yes, life gets busy sometimes, but it's in our best interest to pay attention to these things which matter the most.

Flourishing isn't just a destination, but a direction. And the only way to move in it is to start.

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